



FC COPA ACADEMY

US YOUTH SOCCER **AGE** **CHANGE**

2026 / 27 Season

fccopa.com

FC COPA ACADEMY





W E L C O M E

Dear FC Copa Families,

We want to inform you of important changes being implemented nationally to the youth soccer age-group structure, how they will impact the entire soccer ecosystem, and how they will affect our club.

These changes are being implemented by **U.S. Soccer affiliated organizations**, including US Club Soccer, for the **2026–27 season** — not solely by FC Copa Academy.

As a club with a **21+ year existence**, we have actually navigated these kinds of structural changes before — back in **2014** when the affiliated U.S. Soccer organizations originally moved to the birth-year system currently in use. We face this transition with experience and positivity.

KEY MESSAGE

What's Changing?

CURRENTLY¹

Age groups are determined by a **calendar-year cutoff** — January 1 through December 31.

STARTING 2026–27²

US Club Soccer, US Youth Soccer, and AYSO will move to an **August 1 – July 31** age group window. This is a nationwide governing body decision — not a club change.

EXAMPLE³

A U-8 team in 2026–27 will consist of players born between **August 1, 2018 and July 31, 2019** — instead of January 1–December 31, 2018.

IMPORTANT

No changes take effect for the 2025–26 season. The existing Jan 1–Dec 31 system remains in place for the upcoming Winter and Spring seasons.



IMPACT

What This Means

- | All team age groupings, rosters, and player placements will be reviewed for the 2026–27 season under the new cutoff date.
- | Age group teams will be restructured based on the new birthday windows — teams will not be exactly as they currently are.
- | While the move aims to align players with their school peers, some edge cases may still arise for players who started school earlier or later than average — similar to how "trapped players" existed under the current system.

"We are committed to ensuring transparency, providing you with the information you need, and answering your questions as we transition."





EXAMPLES

REMINDER: NO CHANGES IN 2025–26 SEASON

EXAMPLE 1

Player A — Born March 2014 (6th grade). Currently **U12** (25–26) → **U13** in 2026–27.

Player B — Born October 2014 (5th grade). Currently **U12** (25–26) → **U12** in 2026–27.

EXAMPLE 2

Player A — Born July 2012 (8th grade). Currently **U14** (25–26) → **U15** in 2026–27.

Player B — Born September 2012 (7th grade). Currently **U14** (25–26) → **U14** in 2026–27.



2026 — 27 AGE GROUPS



August 1 – July 31 age group window

FUTURES 5v5

Aug 1, 2018 – Jul 31, 2019

U8

7 v 7

Aug 1, 2017 – Jul 31, 2018

U9

Aug 1, 2016 – Jul 31, 2017

U10

9 v 9

Aug 1, 2015 – Jul 31, 2016

U11

Aug 1, 2014 – Jul 31, 2015

U12

11 v 11

Aug 1, 2013 – Jul 31, 2014

U13

Aug 1, 2012 – Jul 31, 2013

U14

11 v 11 (HS)

Aug 1, 2011 – Jul 31, 2012

U15

Aug 1, 2010 – Jul 31, 2011

U16

Aug 1, 2009 – Jul 31, 2010

U17

Aug 1, 2008 – Jul 31, 2009

U18

Your Questions, Answered.

Q Is there a possibility of kids at Copa to play up an age group if they are on the cut off?

A Yes — each case will be evaluated individually based on what is best for the player's development. These decisions are made after discussion with coaches and directors, and confirmed by the Technical Director for your region.





Your Questions, Answered.

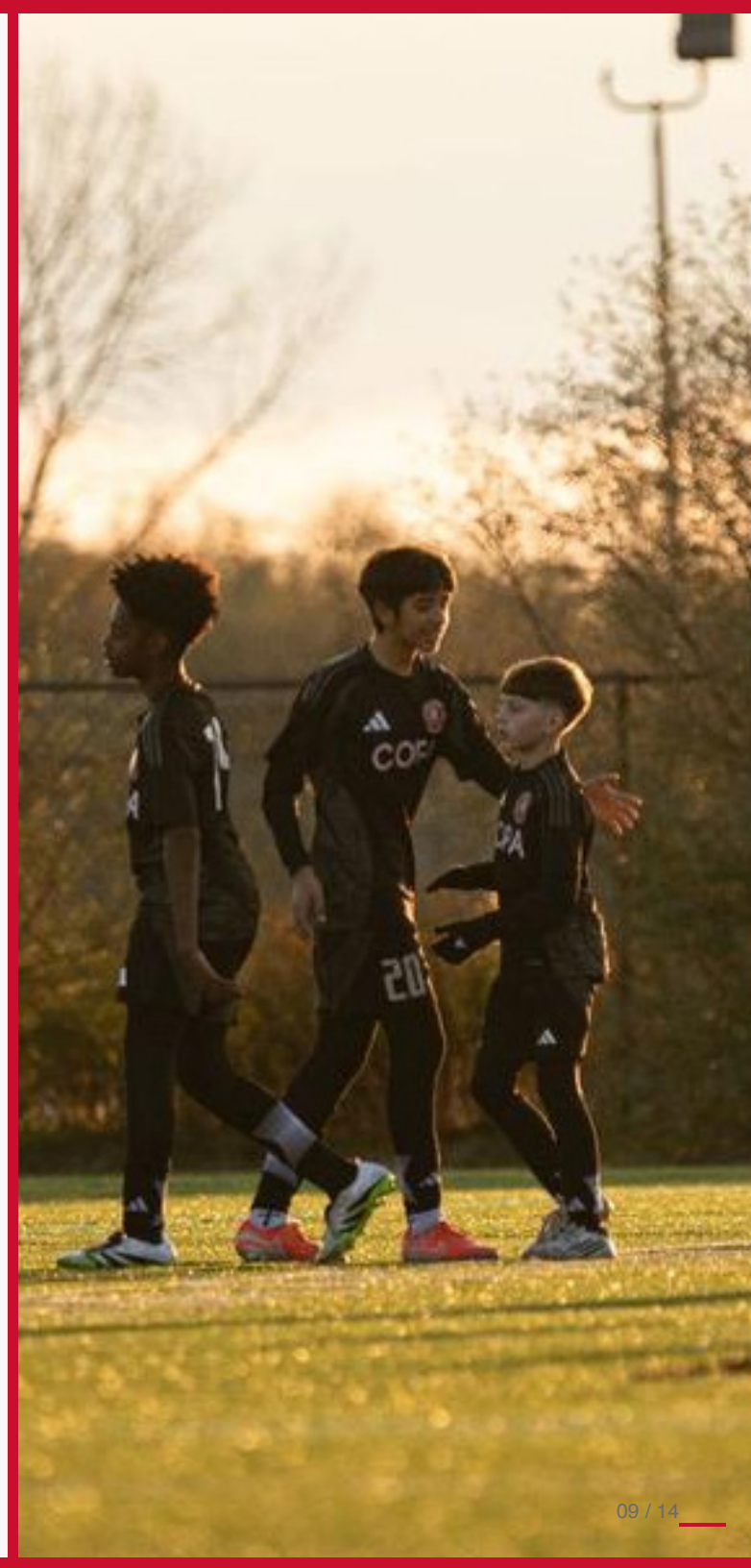
Q So no change to the current COPA rostered teams in the spring 2026 season?

A Correct, this begins in the 26/27 season. The reason you are being informed now is because, as is always the case, you will be receiving discussions and offers for the 26/27 season at the start of the spring season in line with other clubs. Therefore these plans need to be implemented in those offers.

Your Questions, Answered.

Q My child's birthday is October 2013 so that would mean they will be playing on a team with those born in 2014 now?

A Correct, August 1st 2013 through to July 31st 2014 is their new age group format. This would make your child now one of the earlier born players in the year group. This will bring about developmental advantages they previously did not have being a late born birthday in a birth year format.





Your Questions, Answered.

Q What about college recruitment? Won't they be overlooked next year playing with

A We will take into consideration the grade year of players in the HS age groups when determining where players should be rostered.

This is to ensure that if a players birthdate is in the latter part of the year but they are ahead in grade year, they are not 'trapped' in regards to their graduation year. This can only be done in the form of playing up, players are not allowed to play 'down' an age (as is the case currently) even if their school grade dictates they might be in the grade below.

Your Questions, Answered.

Q Is it possible that there will be a change of team or change of coach? Will the teams be realigned at the same level?

A Yes, there is a possibility for players to be on a different team, as many teams will be different under this new age format structure.

We will announce our coaching assignments, as we always do over the summer months ahead of the 26/27 season. There is a potential for your new team to have a new coach. Some of this will be due to the age change and some of this will be due to normal coach assignment movement.

Every player is placed at the level we believe best suits their individual development. Under the new age group format this shifts the category of age which can have an impact on physical, social and psychological development. We will place players where we best believe they are currently within the age group under this new format, as we have done under the previous age group format based on the criteria of their own individual capabilities in comparison with their peers in the age group.



KEY MESSAGE

Clearing Up The Biggest Concern

No one is being downgraded.

US Soccer's age group change is a realignment, not a re-ranking of players. No one is being demoted or labeled as less capable. Players are simply being grouped under new national criteria that every club, league, and pathway under USYS, US Club, and AYSO is following.

This benefits late-born players.

Historically, younger players within an age group have been smaller, less physically mature, and overlooked despite strong abilities. This is known as the Relative Age Effect (RAE). Under the new structure, many of those players will now be among the older players in their group, supporting confidence, development, and long-term opportunity.

Your child's pathway is unchanged.

Their ability, progress, and long-term development trajectory have not changed. Only the framework around them has. We will ensure every player is placed in the right environment to continue growing on and off the field.



NEXT STEPS

What Happens Next

1

Watch for follow-up communications with further details, resources, and timelines leading into the 2026–27 season.

2

We believe the shift to the August 1–July 31 model offers meaningful benefits, aligning club soccer with the school year, improving team cohesion, and enhancing the overall player experience.

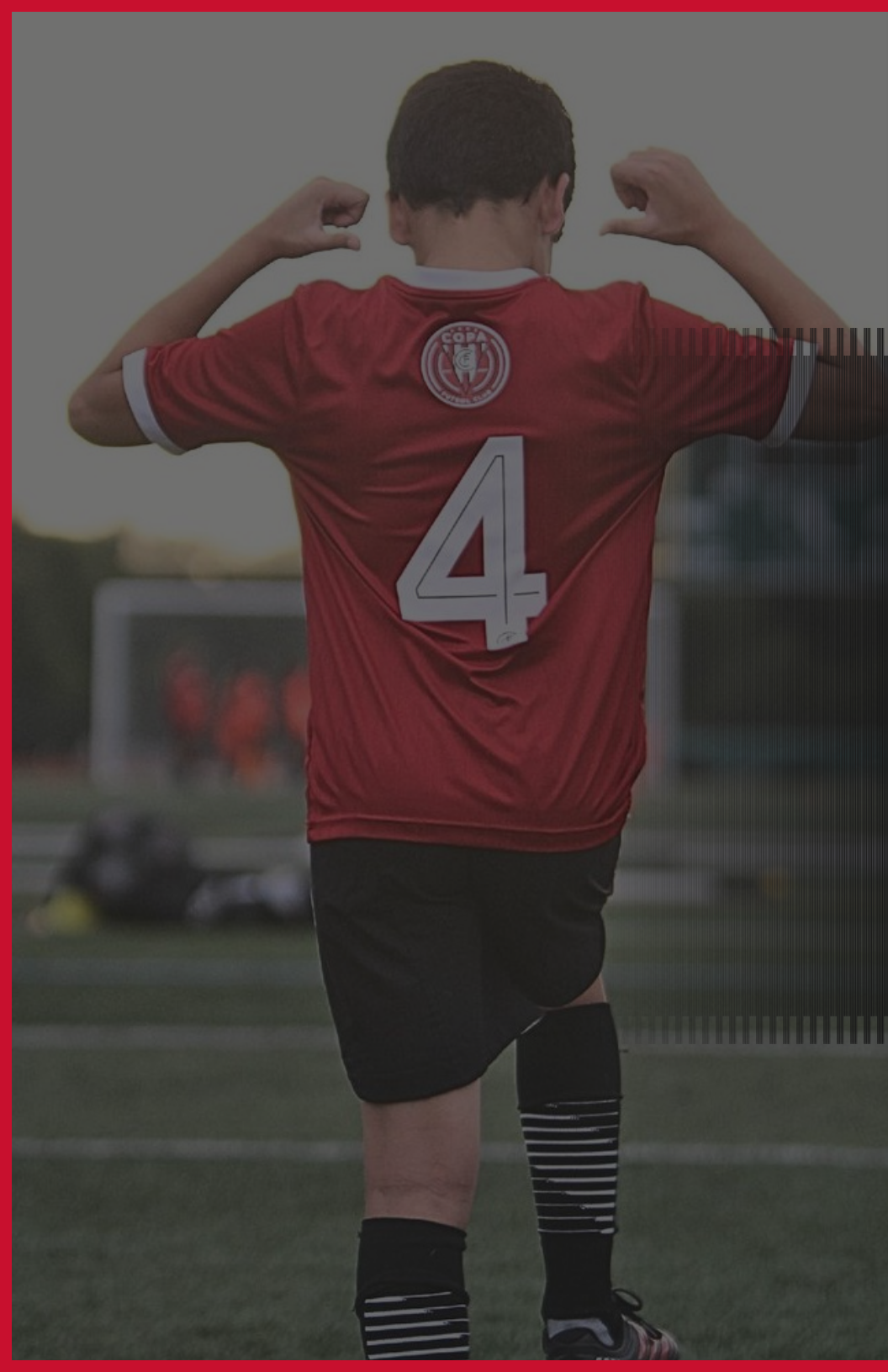
3

We understand this raises questions. Our club is committed to supporting every family through this transition.

4

Thank you for your ongoing trust and partnership in creating a positive, developmental, inclusive soccer experience for all players.





THANK YOU

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